



CentOS

A Blue Feather In Your Red Hat

While everyone else seems to be in a race for the latest and the greatest, CentOS 5.3 still bundles pretty old and tested software. Well, this is not your typical desktop OS; besides, the stability makes it a must-have for your server deployments.

What do you do when you want to run an enterprise grade server but don't have any money to spare for the software? You use free software. Not free as in freedom (Windows Servers cannot be called enterprise grade, so all available enterprise grade server operating systems are freedom software), but free, as in cost.

Let's take the money out of this. If money were no issue, you'd buy a subscription for Red Hat Enterprise Linux. You'd get a copy of RHEL 5.3 and some technical support, and you'd be entitled to upgrades to RHEL.

Bring money back into the equation and you'll think again. A basic subscription for RHEL with two server sockets will set you back about Rs 23,380 per year. That's a basic subscription, meant for SMEs and it's expensive. The most expensive subscription is about Rs 1,67,140 per year.

Now what if I were to tell you that you can get a copy of RHEL, with community support, for use on unlimited servers for an unlimited amount of time — all for free! Yes, it's called CentOS, and it's supposed to be the best free Enterprise Linux out there.

This is what Wikipedia has to say: *"Red Hat Enterprise Linux is a commercial product, available only through a paid subscription service that provides access to software updates and varying levels of technical support. The product is largely composed of software packages distributed under open source licenses, and the source code for those packages is made public by Red Hat."*

It's this source code that makes Community Enterprise Operating System possible. CentOS builds this source code in such a way that the final product is an almost exact clone of RHEL. It's binary compatible